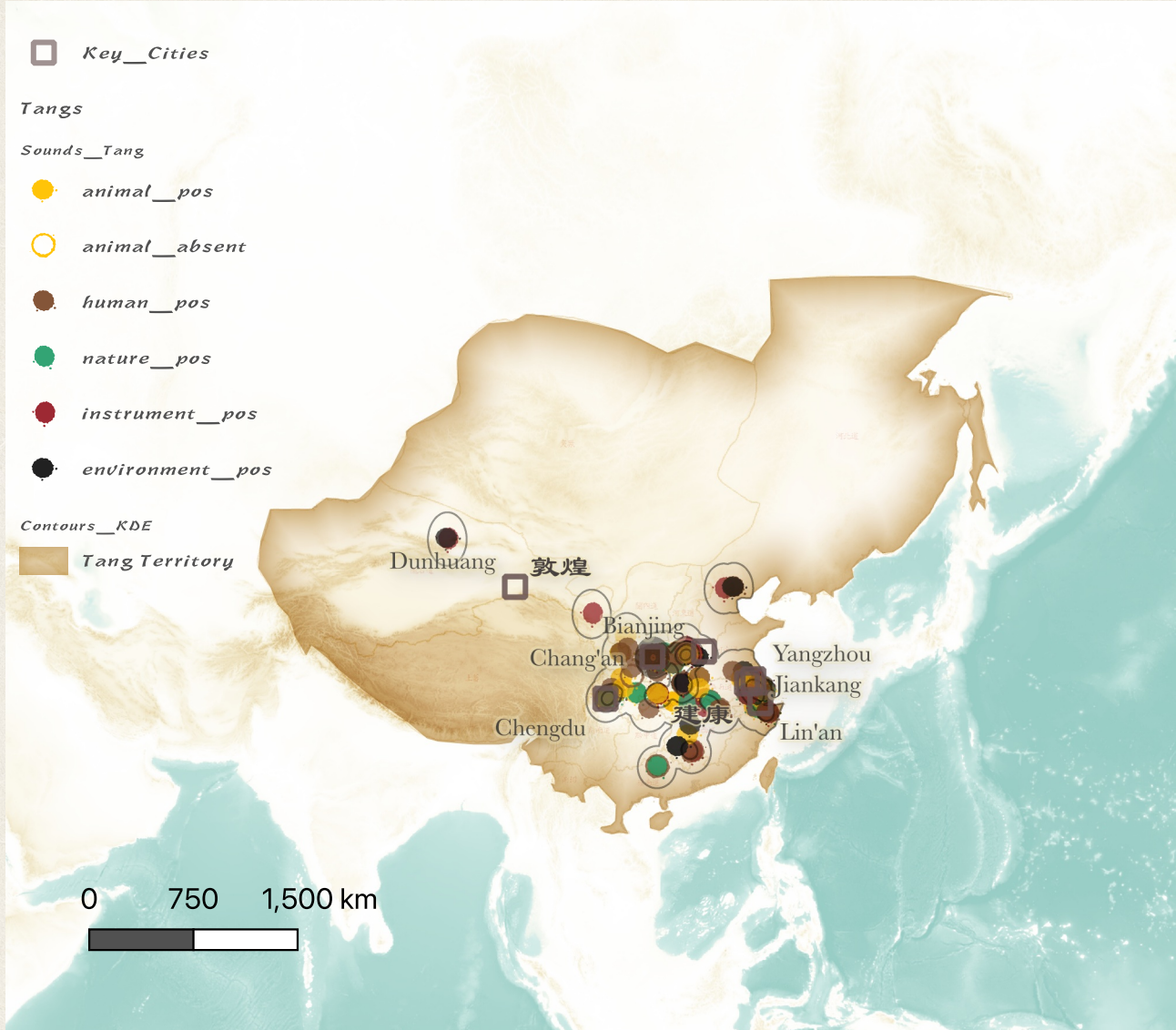
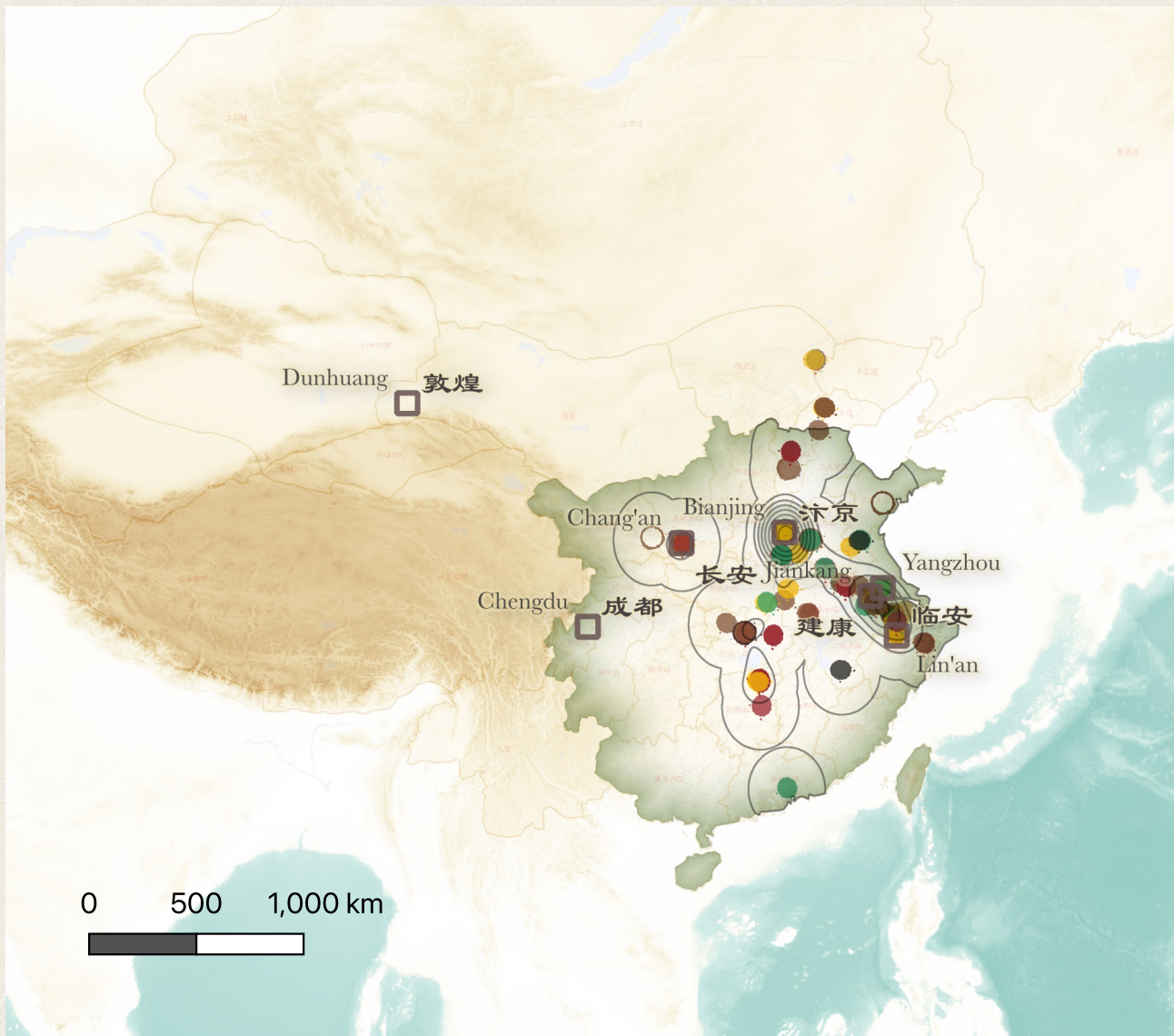


Tang–Song Soundscape

How does the spatial distribution of auditory imagery in Chinese classical poetry shift between the Tang and Song dynasties?



Tang Dynasty, 618 – 907



Northern Song Dynasty, 960 – 1127



Southern Song Dynasty, 1127 – 1279

Key Findings

Overall Spatial–Temporal Patterns

- Capital–Driven Shift:** The center of soundscapes shifted from Chang'an to Bianjing, and finally to the Jiangnan region (Lin'an/Jiankang). This perfectly aligns with the capital cities of the three periods, indicating that poets predominantly clustered around political centers.
- Genre and Instruments:** Song Dynasty poetry ("Ci") features a significantly higher proportion of instrument sounds than Tang poetry. This reflects the nature of "Ci," which were essentially lyrics composed to be sung with musical accompaniment.
- North vs. South:** Across all periods, southern regions consistently show more descriptions of musical instruments and natural sounds compared to the north.

Tang Dynasty

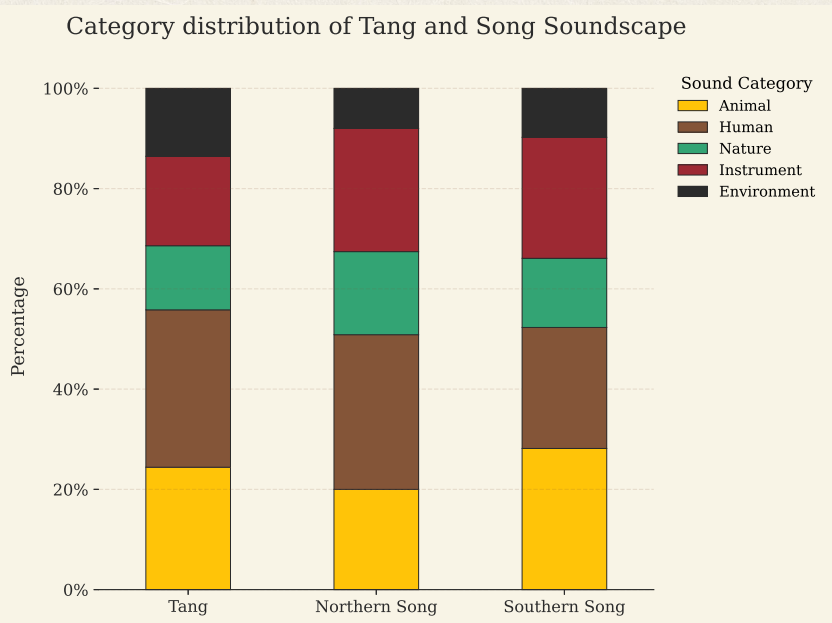
- Broadest Reach:** The primary soundscape center was the Chang'an–Luoyang area, with secondary hubs in Jiangnan and Sichuan. The geographic distribution was the widest, reaching as far northwest as Luntai.
- Regional Variations:** Human-related sounds dominated the Chang'an–Luoyang area (followed by nature and animals), while the Jiangnan region already showed a preference for instrumental sounds.

Northern Song Dynasty

- Radiating from the Capital:** Most sound events radiated from the capital, Bianjing, alongside a strong presence in Jiangnan and scattered points in Chang'an and Hunan.
- Nature in the City:** Interestingly, Bianjing's soundscape featured many nature and animal-related sounds, whereas Jiangnan continued its strong focus on music.

Southern Song Dynasty

- Extreme Southward Shift:** The vast majority of sound events were concentrated in the Jiangnan region (centered around Lin'an) and Jiangxi.
- Sounds Beyond Borders:** Notably, some sound events were mapped in the North, far outside the actual borders of the Southern Song (reflecting memories or longing for lost territories).
- Fewer Human Sounds:** Compared to previous eras, there was a noticeable decrease in the description of human-related sounds.



Data Source: Textual data extracted from 300 Tang Poems and 300 Song Lyrics via LLM.
Base Map: CCTS
Terrain: Mapzen Global Terrain.
Projection: EPSG:3857 - WGS 84
Cartographer: Yuxin Su
Date: 30/04/2026